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Board of Education Report

File #: Rep-042-24/25, Version: 1

Diploma with Alternate Assessment Exemption (PUBLIC HEARING)

October 22, 2024

Division of Instruction

Division of Special Education

Action Proposed:

To provide eligible individuals with exceptional needs, who were enrolled in grade 10 or higher in the 2022-23 school year, with the opportunity to be awarded a high school diploma, pursuant to Education Code Section 51225.32, authorize District schools to extend a graduation exemption from all courses and requirements adopted by the Los Angeles Unified Board of Education (Board) that are additional to the statewide course requirements specified in Education Code Section 51225.3. Eligible individuals are defined as students with an Individualized Education Program (IEP) who are eligible to take the state alternative assessment and required to complete state standards-aligned coursework to meet the statewide course requirements, as noted in their IEP.

Background:

Pursuant to Education Code Section 51225.31, beginning with students in the Class of 2026, Local Education Agencies (LEAs) are required to provide a graduation exemption to all eligible individuals who entered ninth grade in the 2022-23 school year or later. Education Code section 51225.32 allows LEAs, if authorized by their Governing Board, to provide this exemption to eligible individuals who were enrolled in grade 10 or higher in the 2022-23 school year. If authorized, more students would have access to a high school diploma, thus expanding their career and college opportunities. If approved, schools will receive support with IEP amendments and credit recovery opportunities to support eligible students.

Expected Outcomes:

Approval of this action will give eligible students greater access to postsecondary college and career opportunities, especially if a high school diploma is required for their chosen career path. Additionally, this action will increase graduation rates at schools, as previously eligible students who would have only received a certificate of completion, and not been counted as graduates on the California dashboard, will now be recognized as a graduate.

Board Options and Consequences:

If the Board approves this action, all currently enrolled eligible students in the Class of 2025 who meet the minimum California Department of Education (CDE) graduation requirements will be able to receive a high school diploma. Additionally, students who earned a certificate of completion and are still eligible for special education may also be eligible to receive a high school diploma.

If the Board does not authorize the eligibility exemption for high school diplomas, the diploma exemption for alternative assessment will only be available to students who entered 9th grade in the 2022-2023 (Class of 2026) and later.

Policy Implications:

Authorization would alter existing graduation requirements for students with disabilities currently enrolled and eligible for state alternative assessments, who were in grade 10 or higher during the 2022-2023 school year.

Under the new requirements, these students would need to fulfill California's minimum graduation standards, and not local graduation requirements. California requirements include:

- Three year-long courses in English
- Two year-long courses in mathematics
- Two year-long courses in science
- Three year-long courses in social studies
- Two courses in physical education
- One year-long course in either visual or performing arts, world language, or Career and Technical Education

While all courses must meet California State Standards-aligned, they do not need to be A-G approved by the University of California Office of the President (UCOP).

Budget Impact:

Not Applicable.

Student Impact:

The table below displays the number of current students who may qualify for this exemption and extension, organized by graduating class. Eligibility is contingent upon a transcript audit by a counselor. As such, if the Board authorizes the expanded local graduation requirement exemption, students considered to be part of the Class of 2024, 2023, 2022, 2021 and 2020 may be eligible to be awarded a high school diploma if all requirements are met.

Graduation "Class of" Year	Currently Enrolled Potential Students
Class of 2025	499 Students
Class of 2024	444 Students
Class of 2023	389 Students
Class of 2022	371 Students
Class of 2021	291 Students
Class of 2020	38 Students

Equity Impact:

Component	Score	Score Rationale
Recognition	4	The implementation of the diploma with alternate assessment exemption (EC 51225.31 and 51225.32) makes it possible for students who are eligible for the California Alternate Assessment to earn a diploma. Previously, these students were excluded from earning a diploma and could only earn a certificate of completion. Without a diploma, students historically have been unable to apply for some post-secondary and employment opportunities.

Component	Score	Score Rationale
Resource Prioritization	4	Courses and support to achieve a diploma are organized to ensure students in the eligible population are able to earn their diploma. Division of Special Education: Developed course descriptions and materials for use to support high schools and career and transition centers (CTCs) in planning for students to earn a diploma. Teachers: Course descriptions and materials are available through the current curriculum vendor, Unique Learning System. Counseling team: Review of eligible students' transcripts and provide schools with guidance on student programming to meet the CDE minimum graduation requirements.
Results	4	An increased number of students will be eligible to earn a high school diploma and have the ability to continue to participate in district programs due to continued special education eligibility. Students will have more opportunities to access post-secondary education and career options similar to their peers. Students who earn a diploma through this exemption will count as graduates in the CA State Dashboard.
TOTAL	12	

Issues and Analysis:

Though the proposed action is not mandatory, approval may present greater equity and access for all students to earn a high school diploma. Additionally, eligible students in the Class of 2024 who successfully complete graduation requirements may increase the adjusted five-year cohort graduation rate in December 2025. If approved, schools will receive immediate guidance for implementation through Inter-Office Correspondence, frequently asked questions and answers, training on transcript analysis and identification of credit recovery opportunities for eligible students, and IEP guidance.

Attachments:

None

Informatives:

None

Submitted:

10/11/24

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